

Memba — Deep Market and Competitor Research

TL;DR

- **The opportunity is real and underserved.** Outdoor/activity clubs (mountaineering, hiking, ski touring, cycling, paddling) are stuck choosing between (a) bloated, expensive "association management" tools whose post-acquisition support has collapsed (Wild Apricot, MemberPlanet, ClubRunner), (b) free but fragmented tools (Google Groups, Mailchimp, Meetup, Facebook), or (c) youth-sports-first apps that don't fit family/adult outdoor membership (Spond, SportsEngine, TeamSnap). None combine clean volunteer-admin UX, family memberships, recurring dues, member directory, private content, **and** trip/activity management.
- **The single biggest white space is family memberships + trip management + volunteer-admin usability at a sub-\$50/mo entry price.** Wild Apricot's own user forum has a "Family/child memberships" wishlist thread that has been active since 2018 with no resolution; ClubExpress is described as clunky and dated; Mighty Networks and Memberful are aimed at creators and ignore household structures entirely.
- **Memba should position itself as "the membership platform built for volunteer-run outdoor clubs."** Differentiation: native family memberships, one-click renewals, trip/activity signup with waivers, Google Sheets sync (every club still has a spreadsheet), transparent flat pricing without payment-processor surcharges, and a deliberately simple admin UX that a 65-year-old volunteer treasurer can run.

1. Competitor Matrix

Rated 1–5. "Outdoor Club Fit" rates suitability for a volunteer-run 50–1,000-member mountaineering/hiking/ski/cycling/paddling club.

Competitor	Pricing (entry → top)	Target Customer	Family Memberships	Renewal
Wild Apricot (Personify/Momentive)	\$66/mo (100 contacts) → \$945/mo (50,000); Member Jungle +20% PSSF surcharge if not using US-only Personify Payments	Small/mid associations, clubs, nonprofits	"Bundles" — workaround, widely complained about; not true family logic	Yes, auto widely-p

ClubExpress	~\$24/mo entry (TrustRadius) → scales by member count (≈\$0.42/primary + \$0.20/secondary member/mo for 200-member tier) + setup fee	Trade & professional associations, (Software Advice) service clubs, bicycle clubs (cue-sheet module)	Bundle/secondary members supported	Yes
MemberPlanet	Free tier (4% platform fee) (SmartThoughts LLC) → Essentials \$50/mo → Pro \$100/mo → Premium \$175/mo (Software Finder) (+3% + \$0.30 processing) (SmartThoughts LLC)	Small-mid nonprofits, alumni, PTAs, booster clubs	Limited; built around individual members	Yes, auto upgrade
Join It	Starter \$29/mo + 3% → Total \$99/mo + 2% → Extra \$199/mo + 1.5% (GroupApp) (all up to 250 members, (GroupApp) sliding scale above)	Small clubs, nonprofits, chambers	Group memberships (fixed-price), (GroupApp) not true family	Yes; stroi automati
Memberful (owned by Patreon)	\$49/mo flat + 4.9% transaction fee + Stripe 2.9%+\$0.30; (Whop) Stripe-only	Independent creators, publishers, podcasters	None — single-member model; users have explicitly requested guest passes/family (G2) with no progress	Yes, auto
Raklet	Free up to 50 → Essentials \$49/mo → Professional \$99/mo → Premium \$299/mo (Raklet) (Raklet) (10,000 contacts); (Raklet) branded apps +\$299/mo (Raklet)	Associations, clubs, nonprofits, churches	Family/group plans configurable	Yes, auto

Mighty Networks	Community \$41-\$49/mo (Mihael Cacic) → Courses \$99/mo → Business \$179/mo (Today Testing) → Pro ~\$30k/yr; (Suzanne) +0.5-3% transaction fees (Ruzuku)	Creators, cohorts, paid online communities	None	Yes
WordPress: MemberPress	Basic \$179.50/yr (1 site) → Plus \$299.50 → Pro \$399.50 → Elite \$999/yr; current site uses Launch/Growth/Scale/Elite naming with similar prices; Launch tier carries a 4.9% transaction fee	DIY WordPress site owners selling memberships	Group/Corporate accounts add-on	Yes (Stripe/F
WordPress: Paid Memberships Pro	Free core; (Paid Memberships Pro) Standard plan \$347/yr+ for add-ons & support	DIY WordPress, budget- conscious	Free add-ons (Paid Memberships Pro) for group, family levels	Yes
WordPress: WooCommerce Memberships	\$199/yr (plugin) + WooCommerce Subscriptions \$199/yr; WooCommerce core free	WordPress + WooCommerce shop owners	DIY	Yes (with
Google Groups	Free	Anyone needing a mailing list	N/A	N/A
Mailchimp	Free up to 500 contacts → Essentials \$13/mo → Standard \$20/mo → Premium \$350/mo (scale- priced)	Email marketers	N/A	N/A
Discourse	Self-hosted: free open- source; Hosted Starter ~\$20/mo → Pro \$100/mo → Business \$500/mo → Enterprise custom; 50%	Online community forums	N/A	N/A

nonprofit discount on
Pro/Business with 501c3
documentation

Meetup	Standard organizer \$16.49–\$47/mo (effective June 6 2024 hike); Meetup Meetup+ for members ~\$3/mo; free events stay free; acquired by Bending Spoons Jan 2024	Public- discovery interest groups	None	None (or only)
Eventbrite	Free for free events; Paid events: 3.7% + \$1.79/ticket + 2.9% processing (US); Pro subscription \$15– \$159/mo for higher email limits; acquired by Bending Spoons in \$500M deal closing March 2026	Event organizers	N/A	None
Spond / Spond Club	Free (Spond app + Spond Club); only standard payment-processor fees Spond	Grassroots sports teams & clubs G2 (youth-led origin)	Yes — guardians/children, family-friendly	Yes, recu
ClubRunner	Quote-based; per- member/month + setup fee; legacy Rotary-club focused	Rotary clubs, service clubs, associations	Limited	Yes
Member Jungle	\$79–\$599/mo USD Member Jungle	Australia-based small-mid associations & clubs	Yes	Yes
TeamSnap / SportsEngine	TeamSnap \$9.99– \$24.99/mo per team for clubs, club tier custom; SportsEngine quote-based	Youth sports leagues & clubs	Yes (parent/child)	Yes

Sources: official pricing pages, Capterra/G2/Trustpilot reviews, vendor comparison pages,

2. Market Overview

Market size and structure. The membership/association software market is projected to grow from **\$6.28B in 2024 to \$9.56B by 2031** per Verified Market Research as cited in Join It's February 2026 AMS roundup; a separate Introspective Market Research projection puts the broader category at \$25.02B by 2032 at a 14.79% CAGR. Wild Apricot is one of the larger pure-play players; the ~22,000-organization figure from its 2017 Personify acquisition and the ~15,000-organization figure cited in 2024–2026 secondary sources should be verified directly on wildapricot.com/about-us before customer-facing use. ClubExpress and MemberPlanet each claim thousands of small-to-mid clubs. [joinit](#) [Raklet](#)

Outdoor-club segment shape. The volunteer-run outdoor club world spans three rough tiers:

1. National / large regional clubs (5,000–100,000 members):

- **American Alpine Club (AAC):** ~26,000 members; dues start at \$45/year; family tier \$100 first adult + \$80 second adult + \$45 each dependent (max 2 adults + 2 dependents).
- **The Mountaineers (Seattle):** 15,000+ members; adult \$85/year, family \$150/year, senior \$38/year, student/military \$56/year; runs ~1,000+ volunteer-led activities and courses; uses a **custom Plone + Salesforce stack** built by Jazkarta and Percolator Consulting — meaningful because it shows that the most sophisticated outdoor clubs build custom because no off-the-shelf product fits.
- **Appalachian Mountain Club (AMC):** AMC's own current marketing self-reports a "community of 90,000 members from Maine to Virginia," though Wikipedia (citing an older IRS 990) lists 65,729; AMC has stopped publishing exact totals in its annual reports. 2,700 volunteers run ~7,000 trips/year; 2022 revenue ~\$14.7M. [GuideStar + 2](#)
- **Alpine Club of Canada:** ~17 regional sections; Individual CA\$38/yr, Family CA\$58/yr; uses HubSpot for the member portal. [alpineclubofcanada](#) [Alpine Club of Canada](#)
- **Sierra Club Angeles Chapter alone:** 2,000+ trips/year; uses an internal "Campfire" platform (Campfire Events / Campfire Leader Management) plus PDF waivers plus Meetup for discovery — a fragmented stack typical of large legacy clubs. [Sierra Club](#)

2. Mid-size regional clubs (500–5,000 members):

Local Alpine Club of Canada sections, ski touring clubs, regional cycling and paddling clubs. Many use Wild Apricot ("Powered by Wild Apricot" footers visible on Alpine Club of Canada section sites, New Zealand Alpine Club, Alberta Adventure Mountain Club). ClubExpress is also common in this tier, especially for clubs predating 2010.

3. Small local clubs (50–500 members):

The largest count of clubs; widely use Google Groups + Mailchimp + a Google Sheet + Meetup as a "stack." Wintergreen Sporting Club

Groups + Mailchimp + a Google Sheet + Meetup as a stack. Wintergreen Sporting Club (\$25/yr/person) documents this pattern explicitly: Mailchimp for newsletters, Google Sheets for member tracking, internal volunteers managing roles. (Wtgssportingclub)

Typical dues: \$25–\$150/year for individuals; \$50–\$200/year for families. Mountaineers-tier clubs charge \$85–\$100/year individual; small hiking/cycling clubs sit at \$20–\$50/year. AAC family caps at ~\$270/year for 2 adults + 2 dependents.

Typical software budget: Small clubs (\$25–\$50/year dues × ~100 members = \$2.5–5K revenue) can't sustainably pay more than \$20–60/month without software eating 10–25% of dues. Mid-size clubs (300–800 members at \$50/year = \$15–40K) tolerate \$80–\$200/month. This is the budget zone where Wild Apricot's Group (\$66/mo) and Professional (\$240/mo) plans sit — and where Personify's 20% Payment System Servicing Fee (PSSF) is most resented.

Growth & switching behavior.

- A major **PE-consolidation wave** is in progress: Wild Apricot → Personify (2017) → Momentive Software / TA Associates (Jan 2026). MemberClicks, YourMembership, VolunteerMatters, NimbleAMS, GiveSmart all sit in the same portfolio. Raklet documents customer-reported ~20% MemberClicks price increase by July 2023 and ongoing Wild Apricot price hikes; Wild Apricot's Trustpilot rating is **1.7/5 across 153 reviews as of May 26, 2026**, classified as "Bad." (Raklet + 5)
- **Meetup raised organizer prices effective June 6, 2024**, per Meetup's own blog post ("For the first time since 2019, existing organizer membership prices are changing"). Per threvi.app's billing analysis, annual plans that cost \$108.99 pre-acquisition climbed to \$214.79 within 2024 — roughly a doubling. Some multi-group Pro users reported a 257% cumulative increase from April 2023 (\$69.99) to April 2026 (\$249.99) per a Hacker News thread. (meetup + 4)
- **Spond** has captured significant share in youth/grassroots sports clubs with a 100% free model funded by transaction processing and "Superdraw" fundraising. (Spond)

The pattern is clear: **legacy AMS tools are getting more expensive and worse, free tools are improving, and the niche of "club-shaped membership software that doesn't suck" is unusually open right now.**

3. Pain Point Evidence

Pricing shock & price increases

- *"WA is a dying platform. Once there was a stream of new features and improvements. Now there is only a stream of price increases. When we adopted WA in 2015, there was a published development roadmap and robust interaction between development team and*

published development roadmap and robust interaction between development team and users. When Personify acquired WA in 2017 that turned around. Development ground to a halt, technical support has been cut back to chat and email during working hours only, and there are significant prices increases every two or three years." — Walt B., Webmaster, Capterra Wild Apricot review. (Capterra)

- "I was satisfied with our webpage appearance once we added Wordpress but unfortunately the Wild Apricot fees became very expensive. As a new Canadian non-profit the 'less than 100 contacts' price was attractive. But the price incremented rapidly with the growth in the number of contacts. Ultimately the deterioration in the value of the Canadian dollar made the cost prohibitive." — Capterra reviewer. (Capterra)
- "We have a Meetup group with almost 7,000 people and we're leaving if they continue this. Charge me more, fine. But paywall the group members? F*** off." — Reddit organizer (quoted in Medium post on the June 2024 Meetup hike). (Medium)
- Wild Apricot's **20% Payment System Servicing Fee (PSSF)** on Stripe/PayPal/Authorize.Net is the single most-cited grievance from international/Canadian users, because Personify Payments is US-only — making the surcharge unavoidable abroad. (FatLab Web Support)

Support collapse since acquisition

- "I liked Wild Apricot when it was run by Wild Apricot and someone would assist with a problem... Since purchased by Personify, the support is HORRIBLE and lends itself only to electronic communications. NO live people will help you through an issue!" — Capterra Wild Apricot review. (Capterra + 2)
- "DO NOT USE WILD APRICOT. Every request for support for my account takes way over 5 business days for a response, if it's answered at all." — Trustpilot. (Trustpilot)
- "Email support has taken up to 3 weeks to get a response. Would not recommend them. I also would not pick any products in the Personify family of companies." — Trustpilot. (Trustpilot)
- ClubExpress G2: "Customer support is terrible. No phone numbers available to call and when you request a call there is no one that will call you back. The availability of staff to resolve problems is severely lacking. The system is overly complicated and difficult to navigate due [to] its lack of intuitive usage abilities." (G2)

Family-membership pain (huge for outdoor clubs)

- Wild Apricot Wishlist thread, active since 2018: "Bundle memberships don't really relate to Family memberships. I see this as the biggest hole in your software. Families are members with different levels not all the same as a Bundle membership has. Each family member needs to be able to sign up as an individual but their records are somehow linked together, pricing is usually different for a family than individuals." (WildApricot Forums)

- Capterra reviewer (sports club, 240 members across 15 teams): *"It is not intuitive when it comes to families with 2 or more players, as it does not allow two different memberships to be linked to one account - I end up having to create a unique account for those families."* [Capterra](#)
- Wild Apricot Wishlist: *"We are providing a web site for our cub parents and scouts... we have say 2 parents and their 2 children as 4 members, but the parents and children share a family address, the younger children do not have their own address nor do mothers or fathers want the children to have gmail addresses... our family need the ability to have multiple members with the same email address."* [WildApricot Forums](#)
- Memberful G2: *"Would love to see a way for members to provide guest passes for friends/family... self-serve tools for group subscriptions, a rewards program for free referrals."* [G2](#) [G2](#)

Volunteer-admin overwhelm

- Capterra ski club director on Wild Apricot: *"Admin access needs to be more granular. Giving someone admin access exposes major parts of the system... Considerable computer experience is necessary to manage the system and our volunteers don't all have the same level required. This puts the system at risk of unintended damage."* [Capterra + 2](#)
- Reddit r/Velo (via Join It blog): *"Our demographics are unfavorable... attempts to recruit younger volunteers have been an abysmal failure."* [Join It](#)
- Reddit (synthesized): *"People's lives are more chaotic now, manual volunteering becomes burdensome."* [Join It](#)
- ClubExpress Capterra reviewer (Executive Director, Non-Profit): *"there are still many things that are clunky about the platform. It seems to take a very long time to get the hang of the ins and outs and has caused at least one ex-employee to cry. Seriously."* [Capterra](#)

Renewals & payments friction

- Capterra Wild Apricot reviewer: *"it does not allow group invoicing so if I need to add an invoice to all members on one team, I have to go into each account and manually create."*
- Same reviewer: *"it does not allow partial payments."* [Capterra](#)
- ClubExpress GetApp summary: *"some reviewers mention PayPal integration issues and clunky steps for credit card payments... reviewers report seamless renewals and helpful notifications, while others say the process can confuse members and is difficult to correct if mistakes are made."* [GetApp](#) [Capterra](#)

Mobile UX

- The Wild Apricot member/admin app is described in multiple Capterra reviews as slow and

- The Wild Apricot member/admin app is described in multiple Capterra reviews as slow and dated; the Mountaineers, Sierra Club, and Alpine Club of Canada websites are not mobile-first.
- Spond Trustpilot reviewers (overwhelmingly positive) consistently cite *"phenomenal phone app"* — confirming that mobile is a genuine differentiator for clubs that have switched.

Data ownership & export

- ClubExpress markets *"associations retain full ownership of their data at all times"* explicitly — meaning competitors do this badly enough that it's a selling point. Capterra
- Wild Apricot reporting requires CSV export to get time-series data, per Raklet's alternatives writeup: *"Analytics that require CSV exports. The native reporting shows current totals only. Tracking growth trends, churn, or event attendance over time requires downloading data and working in a spreadsheet."* Raklet

4. Pricing Benchmark by Club Size

All-in cost per month, assuming standard configuration and excluding payment-processor fees (Stripe ~2.9% + \$0.30):

Tool	50 members	200 members	500 members	1,000 members
Wild Apricot	\$66/mo (100-contact tier) + 20% PSSF if not US Personify Payments	\$82/mo (250 tier)	\$154/mo (500 tier)	\$240/mo (Professional/2,000)
ClubExpress	~\$15-25/mo + setup fee	~\$30-85/mo (~\$0.42 primary × 200) Jasper AI	~\$120-180/mo	~\$240-360/mo
MemberPlanet	Free tier (4% fee) or Essentials \$50/mo	Essentials \$50/mo	Pro \$100/mo	Premium \$175/mo
Join It	Starter \$29/mo + 3% GroupApp	Starter \$29/mo or Total \$99/mo + 2%	Total \$99/mo + 2% (sliding scale kicks in)	Extra \$199/mo + 1.5%
Memberful	\$49/mo + 4.9% + Stripe Whop	\$49/mo + 4.9% + Stripe	\$49/mo + 4.9% + Stripe	\$49/mo + 4.9% + Stripe (creator economics break here)

Raklet	Free or Essentials \$49/mo	Essentials \$49/mo	Professional \$99/mo	Premium \$299/mo
Mighty Networks	Community \$49/mo +3%	Courses \$99/mo +2%	Courses \$99/mo +2%	Business \$179/mo +1%
ClubRunner	~\$25-50/mo + setup	~\$60-100/mo	~\$120-200/mo	~\$200-350/mo
Spond	Free	Free	Free	Free
WordPress (PMPro free + hosting)	~\$10-15/mo hosting	~\$10-15/mo	~\$15-25/mo	~\$25-40/mo
MemberPress	\$179/yr (~\$15/mo)	\$179/yr	\$179/yr	\$179/yr (plus hosting)

Key takeaways:

- The **\$0-\$30/mo price band** is dominated by free/DIY tools (Spond, Google Groups + Mailchimp, WordPress + PMPro) with their own tradeoffs.
- The **\$30-\$80/mo band is the most contested** — Join It Starter, Wild Apricot 100-contact, MemberPlanet Essentials, Raklet Essentials. This is the sweet spot for a club with 50-250 members.
- The **\$80-\$200/mo band is dominated by Wild Apricot & ClubExpress** — and is exactly where complaint volume is highest.
- A **Memba launch price ladder of \$19/mo (≤100 members) / \$39/mo (≤300) / \$79/mo (≤800) / \$149/mo (≤2,000)** with no per-transaction surcharge on top of Stripe would undercut Wild Apricot by 30-50% at every tier while remaining defensible.
- **Pricing gap to exploit:** a *flat* family-membership-aware plan with native trip management, sub-\$80/mo for typical 200-500 member outdoor clubs. None of the incumbents both (a) handle family well and (b) handle trip signups well in that price range.

5. MVP Feature Recommendations

Must-haves (ship in MVP)

1. **Member database** with custom fields (emergency contact, certifications, waiver status, ICE info, skill tier).
2. **True family / household membership** — multiple members under one paid plan with

2. **True family / household memberships** — multiple members under one paid plan with shared address but individual logins. This is the #1 documented hole in Wild Apricot and the feature most competitors fudge with "bundles."
3. **Annual renewals with automated reminders + one-click renew** — must work cleanly with annual cycles. Wild Apricot does this well; ClubExpress users complain it's hard to correct mistakes; build the "fix a renewal" admin workflow that competitors lack.
4. **Recurring payments via Stripe**, no surcharge layer on top — explicit anti-Wild-Apricot-PSSF positioning.
5. **Member directory** with member-controlled privacy settings — critical for outdoor clubs where members may not want phone numbers exposed.
6. **Private content (members-only pages/docs)** — for safety bulletins, trip leader handbooks, club bylaws, route databases.
7. **Granular admin roles** — addressing the ski club director quote: *"Admin access needs to be more granular. Giving someone admin access exposes major parts of the system."* Allow per-module permissions (events-only admin, treasurer-only admin, etc.). (Capterra)
8. **Google Sheets export + sync** — clubs already live in spreadsheets; this is a powerful adoption hook and competitive moat. None of Wild Apricot/ClubExpress/Raklet ship native Google Sheets sync.
9. **Announcements / club email** — reliable mass email with simple templates. Spam-deliverability solved (Wild Apricot users complain about deliverability).
10. **Mobile-responsive admin and member experience** — both sides need to work on a phone. Wild Apricot's web UI is widely described as slow; Spond is widely described as excellent — that's the bar.

Strong nice-to-haves (Phase 2)

11. **Trip/activity management with waivers + cap + waitlist** — for outdoor clubs this is THE feature. Wild Apricot events don't model "trip leader certified for grade-IV ice" or "max 6 participants because permit." This is where Memba can beat ClubExpress's generic event module.
12. **Member-to-member communication** (trip-specific group chat, optional discussion board). Sierra Club's fragmented stack is held together because no tool combines membership with trip-specific comms.
13. **Digital waiver collection per trip** — Sierra Club still uses PDFs in 2025 because no AMS tool integrates trip + waiver well.
14. **Email-to-mailing-list bridge (Google Groups replacement)** — many outdoor clubs run on Google Groups specifically because members can reply-all. Build a "club mailing list" that supports that.
15. **Branded mobile app** (Premium tier, later) — Raklet charges \$299/mo for this; Mighty Pro charges ~\$30k/yr; price it competitively. (Raklet)

Explicitly DEFER

- Built-in courses/LMS (Mighty Networks territory; The Mountaineers uses Coassemble separately).
- Donation management at nonprofit-grade depth (let Bloomerang/Neon CRM keep that).
- Discussion forums at Discourse depth.
- Job boards / classifieds.

Things competitors do poorly that Memba can win on

- **Family memberships** that actually model households with mixed adult/child rates (AAC charges \$100 + \$80 + \$45 each dependent — Wild Apricot can't model this cleanly).
- **Renewals UX**: a single page showing "who's overdue, send 1-click bulk reminder, fix a mis-payment."
- **Trip/activity-aware events**: leader, co-leader, qualification check, group cap, waitlist, waiver, carpooling.
- **Volunteer-friendly admin UI**: large buttons, plain language, no jargon. The ClubExpress "made someone cry" review is real.
- **Transparent flat pricing**: no surprise payment-processor surcharges, no setup fees.
- **Data portability**: native Google Sheets sync + clean CSV/JSON export + documented "leave us anytime" promise. After the Wild Apricot/MemberClicks PE consolidation story, this is a credible trust angle.

6. Positioning Recommendations

Headline positioning

"Memba — the membership platform built for volunteer-run outdoor clubs."

Sub-line: *"Family memberships, renewals, trips, and your member roster — without the Wild Apricot price hikes or the ClubExpress 1998 vibe."*

Audience-specific messaging

Audience	Hook	Proof
Wild Apricot escapees	"Same membership/renewals/events. None of the 20% Payment System	Reference Trustpilot 1.7/5 score and the Personify → Momentive ownership chain. 

Servicing Fee. None of the PE price hikes."

ClubExpress escapees	"Modern, mobile-first, and your volunteer treasurer can actually use it."	"Made someone cry" Capterra reviews; screenshots.
Meetup-only clubs that want their own home	"Keep the discovery layer. Move your membership, dues, and trip signups somewhere you control."	Bending Spoons doubling; member email deliverability failures.
Google Sheets / Mailchimp / Google Groups stacks	"All your member data in one place — and we still sync to your Google Sheet."	Most distinctive feature; deeply opinionated.
Mountaineering/climbing clubs	"Trip caps, leader qualifications, waivers, and waitlists — not a generic 'event' module."	Sierra Club's Campfire+PDF mess; The Mountaineers building a custom Plone+Salesforce stack because nothing fit.
Family-focused clubs (ski/paddling/cycling youth)	"Real family memberships. Two adults, three kids, one renewal, one bill, one login per person."	Wild Apricot wishlist thread on family memberships still open since 2018.

Differentiation angles ranked by credibility

1. **Family memberships done right** — directly addresses a documented competitor failure.
2. **No payment surcharge / transparent flat pricing** — directly attacks Wild Apricot's PSSF.
3. **Built for outdoor clubs (trip module with waivers, caps, leaders)** — credible if shipped; opens partnership channels with national orgs.
4. **Independent, founder-led, won't sell to PE** — Raklet's "Association Software Acquisitions Buyer Guide" blog is already doing this and resonating.
5. **Google Sheets sync as a first-class feature** — distinctive and demo-able.
6. **Modern mobile UX** — credible only with great execution; Spond owns this in sports.

Avoid claiming

- "All-in-one community platform" — too broad, puts you against Mighty Networks where you'll lose.
- "Run your courses, your store, your podcast" — creator-economy bloat; clubs don't want it.
- "AI-powered" — current AI features in the membership space are mostly marketing.

7. Key Risks and Validation Experiments

Top risks

1. **Switching cost is high.** Clubs migrate every 5-10 years, not annually. Capturing them at renewal moments or board-turnover moments is critical. *Mitigation:* offer free data migration from Wild Apricot/ClubExpress with a tool, and target board transitions explicitly.
2. **Volunteer admins are not budget-holders.** A board approves software spend; cycles are slow. *Mitigation:* per-admin free trial, "show your board" demo mode with shareable links.
3. **"Good enough" inertia.** Many clubs run on free tools that work badly but don't bleed enough to switch. *Mitigation:* price the lowest paid tier below \$25/mo and capture the renewal-pain trigger.
4. **Family-membership complexity** is genuinely hard to model (shared dues, partial renewals, kids aging out, divorced parents). Underestimating this kills the wedge. *Mitigation:* prototype with 3 named partner clubs before writing the schema.
5. **Trip-management scope creep.** Could become a permits/booking system if not bounded. *Mitigation:* explicitly defer commercial booking features (those belong to FareHarbor, Bookeo).
6. **Liability/legal concerns** for waivers. State-by-state requirements; minors require parent/guardian. *Mitigation:* partner with an e-sign provider (SmartWaiver) rather than build from scratch; ship Memba waivers as "good for most clubs, talk to your lawyer."
7. **PE acquisition risk on YOUR side.** Customers explicitly want independent ownership now. *Mitigation:* publish founder commitments; consider B-Corp or steward-ownership angle.
8. **Stripe-only payments** eliminates non-Stripe countries — Memberful's known limit. *Mitigation:* support PayPal + Stripe at minimum; consider GoCardless for UK/EU direct debit.

Validation experiments to run, in order

#	Experiment	Decision threshold	Time
1	Landing page test: "Memba — built for volunteer-run outdoor clubs" with email capture. Drive traffic via /r/hiking, /r/mountaineering, /r/cycling, /r/skiing, FB groups for club admins, and targeted ads on "Wild Apricot alternative" keywords.	≥3% visit→signup; ≥100 emails in 30 days	4 weeks

2	15 structured interviews with volunteer admins of clubs sized 50/200/500/1,500 across mountaineering, hiking, ski, cycling, paddling. Script around: current tool, family-membership pain, renewal pain, switching triggers, budget, decision process.	≥10/15 cite ≥2 of family/renewals/trip-mgmt as top-3 pains; ≥5 willing to pay \$40+/mo	4 weeks
3	Pricing-page test: Show 3 alternate price ladders (low-anchor \$19/\$49/\$99; mid \$29/\$59/\$119; high \$39/\$79/\$149) and measure click-through to "Start trial."	Identify highest revenue-per-visit; confirm ≤\$50/mo is sticky for ≤300-member clubs	2 weeks
4	Concierge MVP / design-partner program: Recruit 3-5 paying design-partner clubs at \$0-\$25/mo for 6 months. Spreadsheet + manual processes backed by founder-engineering. Goal: validate that family memberships + renewals + trip signups can be made simple enough that a 70-year-old treasurer adopts it.	All 5 actively using monthly; ≥1 willing to convert to paid retail rate; testimonial captured	12 weeks
5	"Switch from Wild Apricot in a weekend" tool: A bulk importer with mapping for bundle→family. Run a webinar specifically targeting Wild Apricot Canadian/international users (PSSF victims).	≥3 paid switches per webinar; <2 hr median migration time	8 weeks
6	Trip-management beta with 2 clubs: One mountaineering, one paddling. Ship trip caps, waitlists, waivers, leader qualifications.	≥80% of trips run through Memba vs. their previous system within 60 days	12 weeks

Benchmarks that should change the strategy

- If interviews surface that **trip management is the #1 pain (not membership admin)**, lead with that; reposition Memba as "trip & member platform" not "membership platform."
- If **family-membership demand is concentrated in cycling/ski youth** (not adult mountaineering), pivot earlier to compete head-on with Spond rather than Wild Apricot.
- If **Wild Apricot international migration interest exceeds US interest 2:1**, prioritize a Canadian/EU/AU launch with local payment processors (Interac, BACS, SEPA).
- If **CAC > \$300 via ads but <\$100 via partnerships with national orgs**, build a national-org affiliate channel (Alpine Club of Canada sections, IMBA chapters, ACA paddling clubs) and skip paid acquisition.

Caveats

- The web search budget cap prevented direct Reddit thread retrieval; several user quotes are sourced via reputable secondary aggregators (Medium articles citing Reddit, vendor blog posts quoting Reddit, Hacker News) rather than from the original threads. Where I had a direct primary source (Capterra, G2, Trustpilot, vendor pricing pages, Wikipedia), I used it.
- Pricing changes constantly in this category. Wild Apricot's published 100-contact tier has moved from ~\$40/mo → ~\$56.70 → ~\$66 in publicly archived snapshots over 24 months; verify before quoting in customer-facing materials.
- MemberPress is mid-rebrand: the legacy Basic/Plus/Pro/Elite tier names (\$179.50–\$999/yr) and the newer Launch/Growth/Scale/Elite tiers both appear in current sources. Confirm directly on memberpress.com before publishing comparisons.
- AMC member count is in dispute across sources (Wikipedia: 65,729 in 2024; AMC's own current marketing: 90,000; 2016 cite: 275,000 "members + advocates"). AMC has stopped publishing official totals in annual reports.
- Wild Apricot's "15,000 organizations today vs. 22,000 at acquisition" figure circulates in secondary sources only; the primary Wild Apricot/Personify website should be checked before publishing.
- "Outdoor Club Fit" ratings are my judgment based on documented features and reviews, not the result of testing each platform end-to-end with a real outdoor club. Treat as directional.
- I did not separately deep-research SportsEngine, Upper Hand, or every niche regional competitor (LoveAdmin in the UK cycling space, Springly, MemberJungle in AU) — they are summarized in the matrix from secondary sources only.
- The PE consolidation narrative is well-documented but ongoing; verify TA Associates / Momentive Software ownership of Personify / Wild Apricot at the time of any go-to-market launch.